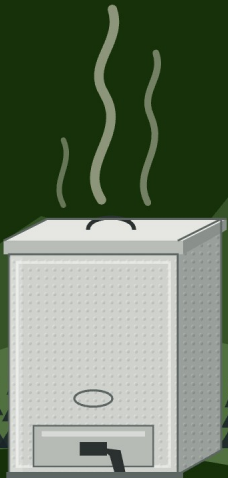




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LYNDON'S SMOKED SALMON SECRETS

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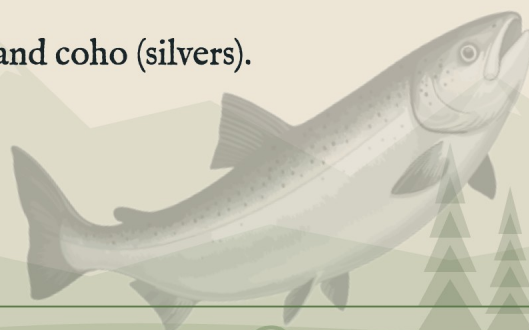
I

STEP 1 OF 17

CATCH A MESS OF SALMON



- Best accomplished in Alaska, but rumor has it you can catch lesser quality salmon in the Lower-48, maybe even steelhead. Three to five fish makes a nice-sized smoker batch.
- Wherever you catch them, bleed them immediately and put on ice as quickly as possible.
- Best results are achieved if you are using fresh salmon that has *never been frozen*. Some Alaskans clean out their freezers in the spring and use old, freezer-burned fish for smoking. I say, cook it for the dog! Fresh salmon makes the best smoked product. I never start with anything but fresh salmon.
- My favorite salmon for smoking are sockeye (reds) and coho (silvers).



2 FILET THE SALMON



- Always have cold beer on hand. Good stuff only.
- Always wear a filet glove. A cut finger might get you temporarily excused from filet duties, but blood does *not* improve palatability of the salmon.
- If you ever find it necessary to store filets in a cooler of ice, make sure they are in watertight ziplock bags. Filets that soak in water get “water-logged” and lose flavor.
- Fresh filets that are kept for more than a few hours may develop considerable slime, from the fish’s skin. Give the filets a quick rinse to get *most* of the slime off, but a little bit of slime doesn’t affect flavor or quality, and gets rinsed off after the brining step anyway.
- It’s not necessary to remove pin bones from filets that will be canned, as they will dissolve during pressure cooking. If you are not canning, they are more easily removed after smoking, if desired.

3

PREPARE THE FILETS FOR BRINING



Note: the photo above shows filets after the brining and peppering steps.

- As a matter of preference, and due to the size of my smoker, I cut each filet in half.
- Each piece is then scored down to the skin in a criss-cross pattern as shown in the above photo. This helps the filets to brine completely and smoke more quickly and more thoroughly. After smoking, the pieces can be peeled off the skin easily for serving or for packing in jars for canning. If you plan to can, the length of the scores should be judged to allow ½” of headspace in half-pint jars. This makes it really easy to pack the jars.

4

BRINE MIX



THE DRY BRINE

4 PARTS
BROWN
SUGAR

TO

1 PART
SALT

- I use a “dry brine” method. Thoroughly combine 4 parts brown sugar with 1 part salt in a large mixing bowl. No liquids added. 1 cup of salt plus 4 cups of sugar is enough for a batch of 5-6 salmon. Make a smaller batch if you have fewer fish, but be liberal with the brine mix!
- There are thousands of wet brine recipes, many using a liquid base of apple juice or white wine, with other added spices or soy/teriyaki. You might consider that if you are using old freezer-burned fish, but again—not me! Fresh salmon and simple ingredients are my standard.
- Pure, non-iodized salt or canning/pickling salt supposedly gives best results, but I find it hard to tell a difference.
- If you prefer a saltier product, use 1 part salt to 3 parts sugar.



STEP 5 OF 17

BRINING



- Rub a liberal amount of the dry brine into each fillet, and deeply into all the scores. This gets a little messy after a while, and the brown sugar starts to stick to your hands. I keep a sink filled with warm water to rinse my hands occasionally, plus a few handy dish towels.
- Layer the filets into a container. Above shows a porcelain-lined pot, but I've since started using a large Rubbermaid food storage container with a sealed lid.
- When I'm done, if I have extra salt/sugar mixture left, I either store it in a sealed container for the next batch, or just spread it on top of the filets in your brining container.

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STEP 6 OF 17

BRINE OVERNIGHT



REFRIGERATE

12-16

HOURS

- The salt/sugar will immediately start to draw liquids out of the filets. This firms the filets, while also providing flavor.
- Cover your container and refrigerate overnight, about 12-16 hours.
- I always re-arrange the filets about halfway through the brining, turning them over and moving top to bottom and bottom to top to ensure that they get completely and evenly brined. Use your hands, to avoid damaging the filets.

7

STEP 7 OF 17

RINSING



- Rinse the filets individually under cold tap water, being sure to get any undissolved dry brine out of the scores.
- I lay filets upside down on an old kitchen towel as I rinse them. When done, I turn them over and blot excess moisture off the top with paper towels or another kitchen towel.
- Arrange filets on your smoker racks and sprinkle liberally with black pepper. Some folks use lemon pepper, garlic pepper, or cajun seasoning.

CLEAN-UP TIP

When you are done, the best way to clean the towels (or your filet glove) is by adding about a cup of white vinegar to a sink (or bucket) of water, and dunk the towels in it. Vinegar dissolves fish slime, and removes the odor. A dish cloth dipped in vinegar/water solution also works well to clean fish slime from cutting boards. Wish I'd learned this about 25 years ago!

What you intend to do with your smoked fish determines the next step:

TO SERVE OR FREEZE

AIR DRY FIRST

If you plan to serve your smoked salmon filets or vacuum package them for freezing, you will want to air dry the filets before smoking. Air drying for several hours builds a thin pellicle on the filets and keeps oils from coming to the surface during the smoking step. This doesn't hurt anything or affect the flavor—only the appearance. If you want your salmon to look as great as it tastes, don't skip this step.

ALWAYS AIR DRY FILETS THAT YOU INTEND TO SERVE OR FREEZE.

TO CAN

STRAIGHT TO THE SMOKER

However, if you plan to pack your smoked salmon into jars for canning, put the racks immediately into the smoker, no air-drying required. In fact, air drying will cause canned salmon to turn much darker in color during pressure-cooking, and sometimes it gets too dry.

DO NOT AIR DRY FILETS THAT YOU INTEND TO CAN.

NEXT: STEP 9, AIR DRYING →

NEXT: SKIP TO STEP 10 →

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STEP 9 OF 17

AIR DRYING

Applies only for smoked salmon that you do *not* intend to can (see previous page).



Air dry for several hours in a cool, well-ventilated place until the filets look dull and glazed, and feel slightly sticky to the touch. A small electric fan can speed the process. In Alaska, it doesn't get warm enough to cause any problems during this step, but you might have to use your judgement in a hot/humid climate. The biggest problem in AK is that doing this outdoors might attract neighborhood bears!

STEP 10 OF 17

IO SMOKER CHIPS



I've always found best results using alder or apple chips, or a combination of both.

Hickory and mesquite are too strong for salmon, but again, it's whatever you like.

The Luhr Jensen brand is readily available in Alaska stores, and works well in my 25-year-old Luhr Jensen "Big Chief" electric smoker. With five racks fully loaded, I can smoke 6 or 7 medium sized salmon (sockeyes or cohos) in one batch. And that's enough to fill about 20-24 half-pint canning jars.

STEP 11 OF 17

II SMOKING!



SMOKER TEMPERATURE ABOUT 140°

- Preheat the smoker and chip pan. My smoker only reaches about 140 degrees on a warm day, but it doesn't need to be any hotter.
- Load the racks into the smoker, and fill the chip pan immediately.
- As soon as it quits smoking (usually about an hour), I refill the chip pan a second time, and again a third time.

I2 How long?



Again, it depends on what you do with the finished product:

CANNING

3-4 HOURS

If you are canning the fish, you are smoking it only for the flavor. You don't want it to get dry in the smoker. And it should be quite soft and raw. The cooking occurs during the canning process. I find that 3-4 hours is all it takes in my smoker.

SERVING OR FREEZING

8-12 HOURS

If you are planning to serve or freeze the filets, you'll need to leave it in the smoker for longer. For my Big Chief, that means 8-12 hours. Rotate racks every few hours and check for doneness about every thirty minutes when it gets close to what you think you want. But err on the safe side, don't let it get too dry.